

Exposition of the Qualities Refined through the Path of Liberation

Vimuktamārgadhutaguṇanirdeśa · Toh 306 · Derge Kangyur

རྣམ་པར་གསོལ་བའ་ལམ་ལས་སྒྲུས་པའ་ཡིན་ཏེ་བསྒྲུ་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ

Toh 306 in the Kangyur is a sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Vimuktamārgadhutaguṇanirdeśa and in Tibetan as the Exposition of the Qualities Refined through the Path of Liberation. It is a discourse on the ascetic or "dhūta" qualities — a set of refined spiritual practices cultivated through disciplined renunciation — presented as essential virtues for yogic practitioners who aspire to liberation through perfectly pure moral conduct. The text enumerates qualities such as few desires, contentment, modest requisites, diligent effort, and the thorough cutting off of attachment, framing these as the foundation for guarding and deepening ethical practice. It belongs to the sūtra division of the Kangyur and opens with a homage to Mañjuśrī, suggesting a connection to that bodhisattva's association with wisdom and spiritual instruction.

The Sūtra of Supreme Attribution is complete.

Homage to Mañjuśrī, the Youthful.

This text is known in Sanskrit as the Vimuktamārgadhutaguṇanirdeśanāma, and in Tibetan as the Exposition of the Qualities Refined through the Path of Liberation.

A practitioner of yoga who desires to undertake the practice with perfectly pure moral discipline, and who seeks qualities with earnest aspiration, should rightly take up the refined qualities and enter into them. The refined qualities of the yogic practice, when properly taken up, manifest in many categories: having few desires, contentment, sparse and modest requisites, application of diligent effort, being easy to satisfy, being established in awareness, and thoroughly cutting off attachment. These, moreover, illuminate the proper guarding of moral discipline, the accumulation of meditative absorption, and the lineage of the noble ones, and they illuminate the supreme qualities in all those who hold them.

Among the thirteen refined qualities, two pertain to robes: wearing rag-robes, and wearing the three Dharma robes. Five pertain to food: going on almsround, going in consecutive order, eating at one sitting, eating a measured portion of food, and not accepting food afterward. Five pertain to

lodging: dwelling in a hermitage, dwelling at the foot of a tree, dwelling in the open air, dwelling in a charnel ground, and accepting whatever place presents itself. One pertains to diligent effort: the practice of sitting up rather than lying down.

Regarding these, the essential nature of each quality is just as its name states, and the meaning of the remaining terms should likewise be explained in the same way. Wearing rag-robcs means renouncing robes given by householders. Wearing the three Dharma robes means renouncing a fourth robe. Going on almsround means renouncing going to invited meals. Going in consecutive order means renouncing passing by houses selectively. Eating at one sitting means renouncing sitting down a second time to eat. Eating a measured portion of food means renouncing eating too much. Not accepting food afterward means renouncing taking additional food. Dwelling in a hermitage means renouncing dwelling at the edge of a village. Dwelling at the foot of a tree means renouncing dwelling under cover. Dwelling in the open air means renouncing dwelling under cover and at the foot of trees. Dwelling in a charnel ground means renouncing dwelling elsewhere. Accepting whatever place presents itself means renouncing lodging that is driven by attachment and craving. The practice of sitting up means renouncing lying down.

Now, how does one rightly take up the practice of wearing rag-robcs? One sees the faults of seeking robes from householders, of taking possession of them, and of requesting them from others; and seeing also the qualities of wearing rag-robcs, one who abides in that training declares: "From this day forth I renounce robes from householders and rightly take up the wearing of rag-robcs." In this way it is rightly taken up.

The qualities of wearing rag-robcs are these: it is consonant with the commitment one has made; it is in harmony with one's own purpose; it does not depend on others; it does not require seeking out; when used there is no excessive attachment; there is no craving; it cannot be stolen by thieves; it is always fitting regardless of the time; it causes little bother; it is the mark of one with sparse and modest requisites; it is the conduct of a noble person; it is endowed with qualities that bring clarity; those who come after see it and follow it; it makes authentic practice apparent; and it is praised by the Victors. Such as these are the qualities of wearing rag-robcs.

Of how many kinds is the wearing of rag-robcs? What constitutes wearing rag-robcs? And what ruins the wearing of rag-robcs? The wearing of rag-robcs

is of two kinds:

the first being ownerless cloth, and the second being cloth that is by its very nature known among people as despised. Of these, rags gathered from a charnel ground, from a heap of discarded cloth, from a marketplace, or from a main road, which are then sewn into a patched robe and worn — this is the rag-robe practice of ownerless cloth. Cloth with its edges cut, cloth with its corners cut, cloth chewed by oxen, cloth gnawed by rats, cloth scorched by fire, cloth used as a birth-cloth, cloth used as a shroud, and cloth that bears the marks of non-Buddhist adherents — these are the rag-robe practice of cloth that is by its very nature known among people as despised. The rag-robe practice is the renunciation of householder's cloth. By accepting householder's cloth, the rag-robe practice itself is ruined.

As for how one authentically takes up the triple-robe practice: one sees the faults of seeking out additional robes beyond the three, of hoarding them, of having to arrange for their suitability, and of being weighed down by excess. And one also sees the qualities of the triple-robe practice itself, and declares: "From this day forward I abandon the fourth robe and authentically take up the triple-robe practice." In this way one authentically takes it up.

The qualities of the triple-robe practice are these: it is a manner of being content to move about lightly; it is the complete abandonment of accumulation and storing; it is being lightly burdened; it is knowing contentment, sustaining the body with little; it is going wherever one wishes as one pleases; it is the conduct of a noble person; and it is a manner of keeping one's requisites lean. Such as these are the qualities of the triple-robe practice.

Of how many kinds is the triple-robe practice? What constitutes the triple-robe practice? And what ruins the triple-robe practice? The three Dharma robes are the patched robe, the upper robe, and the lower robe — these are the triple robes. The triple-robe practice is the renunciation of the fourth robe. By keeping a fourth robe, the triple-robe practice itself is ruined.

As for how one authentically takes up the practice of going for alms: one sees the faults of going as a guest — that one's own practice suffers, that one falls under another's power, that one encounters what is uncongenial, and that one's sitting in meditation becomes feeble. And one also sees the qualities of the alms-going practice itself, and declares: "From this day forward I abandon going as a guest and authentically take up the alms-going practice." In this

way one authentically takes it up.

The qualities of the alms-going practice are these: it is in harmony with one's vowed abode; it is independence; it is not being supported by another; it is freedom from laziness; it is the crushing of pride; it is entering into the work of benefiting sentient beings; it is turning away from craving for tastes; it is being unobstructed in all directions; it is the conduct of a noble person; and it is a manner of keeping one's requisites lean. Such as these are the qualities of the alms-going practice.

Being a guest is a subdivision of the alms-going practice. What is the alms-going practice? And what ruins this alms-going practice? Being a guest is the third subdivision: being invited as a guest to any sort of meal today, or tomorrow, or whenever one pleases — that is being a guest. The alms-going practice is the renunciation of going as a guest. By accepting an invitation as a guest, the alms-going practice itself is ruined.

As for how one authentically takes up the practice of going in sequence house to house: one sees the fault of going only to those particular houses where much and fine food is to be had, moving only from one such place to another — for then one resembles a rice-and-food merchant, and one's manner is not that of keeping one's requisites lean. And one also sees the qualities of the practice of going in sequence, and declares: "From this day forward I abandon indicating a preference for particular houses and authentically take up the practice of going in sequence." In this way one authentically takes it up.

The qualities of the practice of going in sequence house to house are these: evenness of mind; tenderness toward sentient beings; abandonment of miserliness toward households;

not seeing faults in going to houses; not rejoicing in being summoned; not selecting fine foods; complete liberation from the grip of people; thorough abandonment of living in company; and keeping one's requisites lean. These and the like are the qualities of the practice of going in sequence.

What is going in sequence? What abandons going in a mixed-and-wandering way? And what destroys this very practice of going in sequence? When one practices alms-round by going in sequence, one goes in sequence from the first house to the last house. Going in sequence is what abandons going in a mixed-and-wandering way. And going in a mixed-and-wandering way destroys the very practice of going in sequence.

How does one authentically take up the practice of eating at one sitting? One sees the fault of keeping one's requisites lean in the manner of eating by sitting down a second time, which constitutes eating again and again while seated, and of being satisfied with indulgence in full enjoyment. One also sees the qualities of the practice of eating at one sitting, and declares: "From this day forward I abandon eating while sitting down a second time, and authentically take up the practice of eating at one sitting." In this way one authentically takes it up.

The qualities of the practice of eating at one sitting are these: proper digestion of what has been eaten; freedom from craving; not eating in excess; wanting little; a comfortable complexion; not deteriorating in one's own practice; abiding in touch with reality; the conduct of a true person; and keeping one's requisites lean. These and the like are the qualities of the practice of eating at one sitting.

How many kinds of eating at one sitting are there? What is eating at one sitting? What is the limit of the meal? And what destroys this practice of eating at one sitting? There are three kinds of one-sitting eating: that bounded by the seat, that bounded by water, and that bounded by the meal. Of these, "bounded by the seat" means that after eating one rises from one's seat and does not eat again. "Bounded by water" means that after eating, even while remaining seated, one takes up water with one's bowl and does not eat again. "Bounded by the meal" means that while eating, once one has swallowed the last mouthful, one does not eat again. The practice of eating at one sitting is the abandonment of eating while sitting down a second time. The limit of the meal is whatever is acceptable short of water and medicine. Eating while sitting down a second time destroys the very practice of eating at one sitting.

How does one authentically take up the practice of eating in moderation? One sees the faults of keeping one's requisites lean in the manner of eating much food, which makes the body heavy, produces sluggishness, and gives rise to great desire. One also sees the qualities of the practice of eating in moderation, and declares: "From this day forward I abandon eating much food, and authentically take up the practice of eating in moderation." In this way one authentically takes it up.

The qualities of the practice of eating in moderation are these: freedom from sluggishness; knowing the measure of one's food; knowing the point of eating too much; restraining the body's ill-maintained habits; abandoning attachment

to that; knowing what brings little harm; thoroughly abandoning agitation; the conduct of a true person; and keeping one's requisites lean. These and the like are the qualities of the practice of eating in moderation.

How does one determine the measure of one's food? What constitutes eating in moderation? And what destroys this practice of eating in moderation? Taking a small vessel of rice as one's measure of a full bowl, one assesses the sign of sufficiency — discerning with care — and is skilled in recognizing the sign that means one should take no more after that. When one has trained in this way, one will come to know the limit of one's stomach as well. Eating in moderation is the abandonment of eating much food.

Eating beyond the measure of one's food destroys the practice of eating in moderation.

How does one properly take up the practice of not accepting food afterward? One sees the faults of eating surplus food: it gives rise to vomiting, it creates dependence on others, and it is a mark of not being restrained in one's requisites. And seeing the qualities of the practice of not accepting food afterward, one resolves in these words: "From this day forward I abandon surplus eating and properly take up the practice of not accepting food afterward" — and so one takes it up properly.

The qualities of the practice of not accepting food afterward are these: expectation is utterly cut off; one is easily satisfied; one is not dependent on others; one completely abandons hoarding; one does not seek again; one is free from craving; vomiting does not arise; one conducts oneself as a noble person; and one has the manner of being restrained in one's requisites. These and the like are the qualities of the practice of not accepting food afterward.

How long does one not accept food afterward? What constitutes not accepting food afterward? And what destroys the practice of not accepting food afterward? There are two limits on not accepting food afterward: the limit of the surplus and the limit of what has been taken. The limit of the surplus means that once food has been set aside, one eats no more of it. The limit of what has been taken means that even one who by nature has taken a single portion does not take again. Not accepting food afterward is the abandonment of eating surplus food. Eating surplus food destroys the practice of not accepting food afterward.

How does one properly take up the practice of forest dwelling? One sees the faults of living on the outskirts of a village: it brings disturbance from

unwanted objects, it gives rise to attachment, and it keeps one entangled. And seeing the qualities of forest dwelling, one resolves in these words: "From this day forward I abandon living on the village outskirts and properly take up dwelling in the forest" — and so one takes it up properly.

The qualities of the practice of forest dwelling are these: complete abandonment of unwanted objects; proper instruction in the ten topics of proper conversation; great beauty of character; being stirred by the gods; not seeking out crowds for one's sake; obtaining as much as one desires of the happiness of seclusion; the quietness of the place being conducive to meditative practice; conducting oneself as a noble person; and having the manner of being restrained in one's requisites. These and the like are the qualities of the practice of forest dwelling.

What is the boundary of the dwelling place of a forest dweller? What is a forest dweller? And what destroys the practice of forest dwelling? Excluding a village, its environs, a pleasure garden, and the environs of a pleasure garden, one draws a bow — reckoned at four forearm-lengths of a medium person — and five hundred such bow-lengths: this is the boundary of the dwelling place of a forest dweller. A forest dweller is one who has abandoned living on the village outskirts. Living on the village outskirts destroys the practice of forest dwelling.

How does one properly take up the practice of dwelling at the foot of a tree? One sees the faults of dwelling under cover: it must be maintained, it requires repair, one must petition others for it, and one sees the faults of using such property. And seeing the qualities of the practice of dwelling at the foot of a tree, one resolves in these words: "From this day forward I abandon dwelling under cover and properly take up the practice of dwelling at the foot of a tree" — and so one takes it up properly.

The qualities of the practice of dwelling at the foot of a tree are these: it is in accord with one's pledged dwelling; one is restrained in one's requisites; one completely abandons delight in work; one is stirred by the gods; one abandons miserliness regarding one's dwelling; attachment is thoroughly cut; one conducts oneself as a noble person; and one is restrained in one's requisites. These and the like are the qualities of the practice of dwelling at the foot of a tree.

What is the measure of the tree? What kind of tree is to be avoided? What is a tree-dweller? And what destroys this practice of dwelling at the foot of a tree?

As far as the shadow reaches at midday —

as long as the leaves remain still without wind — that is the measure of the tree.

A tree-dweller should avoid old and rotting trees, hollow trees, and trees that are hazardous. A tree-dweller is one who abandons dwelling under cover. Dwelling under cover destroys the practice of dwelling at the foot of a tree.

How does one properly take up the practice of dwelling without cover? Seeing the fault of dwelling under cover, seeking out a tree as one's place of residence, and not hoarding one's requisites by clinging to them, one resolves thus: "From this day forward I abandon dwelling under cover and dwelling at the foot of a tree, and I properly take up the practice of dwelling without cover." In this way one properly takes it up.

The qualities of dwelling without cover are these: not relaxing one's diligence; abandoning torpor and sleep; being like a wild animal of the forest; surveying all four directions; having no fixed support; conducting oneself as a noble person; and being restrained in one's requisites. These and the like are the qualities of dwelling without cover.

What is a person who dwells without cover? What destroys this practice of dwelling without cover? One who dwells without cover is one who has abandoned dwelling under cover and at the foot of a tree. Dwelling under cover or at the foot of a tree destroys this practice of dwelling without cover.

How does one properly take up the practice of dwelling in a charnel ground? Seeing the fault that dwelling elsewhere causes the mind to become uninspired and breeds much heedlessness, and also seeing the qualities of dwelling in a charnel ground, one resolves thus: "From this day forward I abandon dwelling elsewhere and properly take up the practice of dwelling in a charnel ground." In this way one properly takes it up.

The qualities of dwelling in a charnel ground are these: one attains the recollection of death; one attains the sign of the unattractive; one is revered as a teacher by humans; one is revered as a teacher by non-humans; heedfulness arises; attachment to the objects of desire is thoroughly subdued; much disenchantment arises; one becomes able to bear fear and terror; one abandons the conceit of the living; one repeatedly and individually contemplates the intrinsic nature of the body; one conducts oneself as a noble person; and one is restrained in one's requisites. These and the like are the

qualities of dwelling in a charnel ground.

What kind of charnel ground should one dwell in? Who is a charnel-ground dweller? What destroys the practice of dwelling in a charnel ground?

First, one should dwell in a charnel ground of that kind — one where there is constant burning, smoke, and flames, a charnel ground with smoke. After that, one may dwell in any other charnel ground as well.

A charnel-ground dweller should not set up a folding seat or construct a hut within the charnel ground. One should not dwell there oriented toward the direction the wind is blowing, nor toward the direction it blows from. One should not dwell in a cramped or hunched position. One should not partake of fish, meat, milk, sesame oil, cakes, or food prepared from legumes or grain. One should not give away one's begging bowl. One should not sit in a householder's home. If a crowd of many people has gathered and one has taken one's mat, robe, and bowl and departed, one should dwell within the charnel ground at a distance from the burning that is not too far — no more than a stone's throw away. And if at dawn one takes one's mat, robe, and bowl and goes back — that is not the conduct of this practice.

A charnel-ground dweller is one who has abandoned dwelling elsewhere. Accepting dwelling elsewhere destroys the practice of dwelling in a charnel ground.

How does one properly take up the practice of dwelling exactly as one has been assigned? Seeing the fault that the mutual stirring about over coveted sleeping and sitting places causes harm to others, and also seeing the qualities of dwelling exactly as assigned, one resolves thus: "From this day forward I abandon coveted sleeping and sitting places —

one properly takes up the practice of dwelling exactly as assigned." Thus one properly takes it up.

The qualities of the practice of dwelling exactly as assigned are these: settling inwardly and showing respect to one's superior; being content with whatever one receives; abandoning attachment to one's place; having a mind of loving-kindness; delighting in solitude; being worthy of trust; conducting oneself as a person of noble character; and having the bearing of one who uses few possessions. Such things as these are the qualities of the practice of dwelling exactly as assigned.

What is the practice of dwelling exactly as assigned? And what destroys it? The practice of dwelling exactly as assigned is the abandoning of coveted sleeping and sitting places — that is, one does not displace someone who was seated there first and take that place for oneself. Accepting a coveted sleeping or sitting place destroys the practice of dwelling exactly as assigned.

How does one properly take up the practice of the sitter? Seeing the fault that lying down leads one into the power of torpor, drowsiness, and laziness, and also seeing the qualities of the practice of the sitter, one resolves thus: "From this day forward I abandon lying down." Thus one properly takes up the practice of the sitter.

The qualities of the practice of the sitter are these: complete abandonment of the basis of laziness; non-attachment to the body; complete abandonment of miserliness; non-attachment to the comfort of reclining; little seeking; little sleep; harmony with meditation practice; the body's posture becoming expansive; conducting oneself as a person of noble character; and having the bearing of one who uses few possessions. Such things as these are the qualities of the practice of the sitter.

What is the practice of the sitter? And what destroys it? The practice of the sitter is the abandonment of lying down. Accepting lying down destroys the practice of the sitter.

Regarding allowances for the practice of the rag-robe wearer: if, while one is practicing the rag-robe practice in full earnest, householders give one Dharma-robies of cotton cloth, woolen fabric, fine silk, or gifts of that kind, one may accept them through the allowance — and the practice of the rag-robe wearer will not be impaired.

Regarding allowances for the practice of the three-robe wearer: if one expects to receive something to fill a lack, one may keep a spare robe for up to ten days; to protect one's sleeping place, one may spread something beneath and above; to cover a wound due to illness; a face-wiping cloth; a large cloth for the rains retreat; or something stored as belonging to another — these may be accepted through the allowance, and the practice of the three-robe wearer will not be impaired.

Regarding allowances for the practice of the alms-round: food that has been prepared as an offering, food for the fortnightly ceremony (uposadha), food for the mid-month, food for the restoration and confession ceremony, food for the Saṅgha, and food for the monastery — all of these may be fully enjoyed

through the allowance, and the practice of the alms-round will not be impaired. However, one should enjoy them while regarding them as objects of contemplating their faults.

Regarding allowances for the practice of going in sequence from house to house: if, at a householder's door, one sees an elephant, a horse, a prize stallion, a dog, a fight, or something else similarly causing embarrassment, one may pass that house by and continue; or if a house is unsuitable because the food given there is not fit to eat, or if one passes by a house where the bowl is to be turned upside down, or a house known to have invited one — one may skip these and continue; and if one is going along with a preceptor, an abbot, someone who has come unexpectedly, or a companion, one may also pass ahead through the allowance — and the practice of going in sequence from house to house will not be impaired.

Regarding allowances for the practice of the one-session eater: if, while eating, one sees an elephant, a horse, a prize stallion, a snake, a thunderbolt striking, an abbot, a preceptor, or someone who has come unexpectedly, and if one has risen, one may eat again through the allowance — and the practice of the one-session eater will not be impaired.

For the practices of eating just enough and of not accepting food after the meal, there is no allowance.

Regarding allowances for the practice of the forest dweller: for the purpose of the rite of full ordination,

for the purpose of lifting a transgression, or for the purpose of hearing the Dharma, or for performing the restoration ceremony, or for performing the invitation ceremony, or due to illness, or for the affairs of someone who is ill, or for the purpose of mastering sūtras one does not know — if any such condition as these exists, then through the allowance one may remain at the village's edge, and the practice of the forest dweller will not be impaired.

Regarding the allowance for the practice of the tree-root dweller: if, under conditions such as those, or while sheltering in a house one is overcome by rain, then even if dawn breaks right there, the practice of the tree-root dweller will not be impaired.

The allowances for the practice of the forest dweller apply equally to the practice of the tree-root dweller, the practice of dwelling without a roof, and the practice of the charnel-ground dweller.

Regarding the allowance for the practice of whatever place is assigned: if such a condition exists and another person obtains one's lodging, it is permitted.

For the practice of the one-mat dweller there is no allowance.

Some say that if one is examined for nasal discharge, an allowance applies and the practice of the one-mat dweller will not be impaired.

Those thirteen virtues of ascetic practice, when condensed, amount to only eight, in accordance with what the Abhidharma states: "The virtues of ascetic practice are eight."

If one asks how this is so: the practice of eating just enough and the practice of the one-session eater are included within the practice of not accepting food after the meal. Why? The one who holds to the final limit takes only one's own portion; therefore these are included within the practice of eating just enough. Furthermore, one does not eat a second time; therefore these are included within the practice of the one-session eater. The practice of the tree-root dweller, the practice of dwelling without a roof, and the practice of the charnel-ground dweller are all included within the practice of the forest dweller. Why? The forest dweller, thinking "building nooks and lean-tos in the forest, and so forth — to delight in such work, to hold onto things, to be attached — these are not my portion," dwells therefore at a tree-root, under open sky, or in a charnel ground. Thus the number becomes only eight, and those eight are perfected by three: the practice of the forest dweller, the practice of the rag-robe wearer, and the practice of the almsgiver.

In this way, when one perfects the three doors of ascetic practice, all the virtues of ascetic practice are perfected. For this very reason the Blessed One, speaking in dependence on the Venerable Nandaka, said: "Nandaka, observe that those who wish to live in the forest, who wear rag-robes, and who sustain themselves by ignoble means are without right view."

Now, what are the limbs of ascetic practice? How many are the qualities of ascetic practice? Who are the persons who practice them and who delight in demonstrating the virtues of ascetic practice? How many are the limbs of ascetic practice? What is its culmination? Is one who has trained in ascetic practice the same as one who speaks of having trained?

In answer: what is called "the limb of ascetic practice" is the abandonment of those thirteen bases — that is the limb of ascetic practice. As for what the virtues of ascetic practice should be called, they should be called virtuous. As

for how many qualities of ascetic practice there are: the qualities of ascetic practice are two — non-attachment and non-delusion. The Blessed One declared: "Whoever is a rag-robe wearer, it is in dependence on desiring little, in dependence on contentment, in dependence on using few implements, in dependence on deep seclusion, and in dependence on finding sufficiency in this — that one becomes a rag-robe wearer."

In one aspect, through non-attachment one practices appropriately within the permitted allowances, thereby dispelling the deception of striving after almsgiving out of desire. The virtue of ascetic practice that is non-delusion, through practicing appropriately with few implements, dispels the deception of striving in a way that exhausts oneself.

Therefore the qualities of ascetic practice are two: non-attachment and non-delusion. Of these, desiring little, contentment, and deep seclusion constitute non-attachment. Using few implements and finding sufficiency in this constitute non-delusion. Non-attachment dispels attachment to the thirteen bases of abandonment, while non-delusion dispels the failure to see the faults inherent in those very bases.

Now, one might ask: what kind of person is it who delights in relying on the virtues of ascetic practice? Those who conduct themselves through attachment and those who conduct themselves through delusion delight in relying on the virtues of ascetic practice, but those who conduct themselves through aversion do not. Why is it that those who conduct themselves through attachment and those who conduct themselves through delusion rely on the virtues of ascetic practice, while those who conduct themselves through aversion do not?

Relying on the virtues of ascetic practice is something difficult to accomplish. Because it is difficult to accomplish, one who conducts oneself through attachment, by relying on this difficulty, comes to subdue attachment. One who conducts oneself through delusion, having properly undertaken the reliance on the virtues of ascetic practice and its use of few implements, becomes constantly vigilant, and through vigilance comes to subdue delusion. Therefore those who conduct themselves through attachment and those who conduct themselves through delusion delight in relying on the virtues of ascetic practice.

As for one who conducts oneself through aversion, when what is difficult to accomplish instead generates renewed aversion — like applying warmth to an

ailment of bile — it results in aversion arising again. Therefore it is difficult for one who conducts oneself through aversion to rely on the virtues of ascetic practice. Others, however, say that one who conducts oneself through aversion does delight in dwelling at the foot of a tree and in forest solitude. Why? Because when dwelling in a forest or at the foot of a tree, there are no beings present who could cause harm through unwanted intrusion, and so no fault of injury arises — or so they say.

The question of how long the limbs of ascetic practice last is answered as follows. Three of the limbs of ascetic practice — dwelling at the foot of a tree, dwelling without a roof, and dwelling in a charnel ground — are to be maintained for a period ending at eight months. For the rains retreat, the Blessed One permitted dwelling under cover.

The question of whether one who is ascetic is also one who speaks of asceticism is answered thus. There is one who is ascetic and also speaks of asceticism. There is one who is not ascetic but speaks of asceticism. There is one who is ascetic but does not speak of asceticism. And there is one who is neither ascetic nor speaks of asceticism.

Of these, one who is both ascetic and speaks of asceticism is an arhat who possesses the virtues of ascetic practice properly undertaken. One who is not ascetic but speaks of asceticism is an arhat who does not possess the virtues of ascetic practice properly undertaken. One who is ascetic but does not speak of asceticism is either a trainee or an ordinary person who possesses the virtues of ascetic practice properly undertaken. One who is neither ascetic nor speaks of asceticism is either a trainee or an ordinary person who does not possess the virtues of ascetic practice properly undertaken.

One might then ask: what is the defining characteristic (*lakṣaṇa*) of the virtues of ascetic practice? What is their essence? What is their support? The defining characteristic of the virtues of ascetic practice is desiring little. Their essence is contentment. Their support is using few implements. In another aspect, the defining characteristic is being unimpaired. The essence is being free from fault. The support is not abandoning diligence.

One might further ask: what is the beginning of the virtues of ascetic practice, what is their middle, and what is their end? The beginning of the virtues of ascetic practice is proper undertaking. The middle is reliance upon them. The end is thorough purification.

This concludes the teaching on the virtues of ascetic practice from the Path of Liberation, being the third collection in its entirety.

Translator's Notes

- The text opens with a colophon closing a prior sūtra ("The Sūtra of Supreme Attribution is complete") before beginning the new text. The thirteen dhutaṅgas, the ascetic or refined qualities, are a standard Vinaya-related list found in Pāli and Sanskrit sources; the Tibetan renders the Sanskrit dhuta as sbyangs pa, meaning "refined" or "purified by shaking off." The quality rendered "dwelling in the open air" translates bla gab med pa, literally "without overhead cover," which is the standard open-air dwelling practice. The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of this passage.
- The term rendered "birth-cloth" for རྩེད་ཆས་ is a garment used at childbirth; some commentators gloss it as the cloth associated with a birth or afterbirth, and the rendering follows that tradition. The term རྩེད་ཆས་, rendered "shroud," literally refers to a cloth wrapping a corpse.

The phrase 家家門戶, rendered "going in sequence house to house," describes the practice of proceeding from one end of a village to the other without skipping any household, accepting alms indiscriminately. The simile of the "rice-and-food merchant" (米食商) conveys that going only to the best houses makes the monk resemble a trader seeking profit rather than a practitioner content with whatever is offered.

- The phrase rendered as "abiding in touch with reality" translates a term literally meaning "remaining in contact" or "dwelling in the felt." In the Vinaya context of ascetic practices this likely means abiding in the direct, unmediated quality of present-moment bodily experience — a sense of immediacy and groundedness. The rendering is interpretive.

The term rendered as "sluggishness" literally means something like "being born dull" or "arising dull," pointing to the post-meal heaviness and dullness of mind that too much food produces.

- The phrase rendered "ten topics of proper conversation" translates a term that refers to a standard list of suitable subjects for discussion among monastics, such as fewness of desires, contentment, seclusion, and so forth. The rendering is conventional.

The boundary measurement combining forearm-lengths and bow-lengths reflects a traditional Vinaya reckoning; the passage is abrupt, as it is a continuing text, and the full definition of the boundary is given only up to the point the Tibetan breaks off.

- The phrase rendered "dwelling exactly as one has been assigned" translates सत्तमसंन्यास, literally "the practice of being as the basis is" or "being as things are placed." In the context of the ascetic practices (Skt. *dhūtaguṇa*), this refers to the practice of accepting whatever lodging is assigned by the community without seeking out or preferring particular spots, often rendered in Pali scholarship as "yathāsanthatika" (taking whatever bed or seat is prepared). The rendering "dwelling exactly as one has been assigned" follows the commentarial sense.

The list of foods one should not partake of in the charnel ground follows a traditional enumeration of rich or stimulating foods considered incompatible with austere practice in that setting.

- The phrase rendered "the fortnightly ceremony" translates a term literally meaning "wood of the rule" or "rule-wood food," which is a variant expression in Vinaya literature for food associated with the uposadha observance. The rendering follows context and standard Vinaya

usage.

The term rendered "a house where the bowl is to be turned upside down" refers to a Vinaya convention whereby a monk formally declines alms from a particular household by inverting the bowl — a house with this status is to be passed over on the alms round.

- The passage containing the Blessed One's words to Nandaka is doctrinally unusual: the Tibetan reads that the Buddha told Nandaka to observe that forest-dwellers, rag-robe wearers, and those wishing to subsist by ignoble means "are without right view." This seems to be a corrective teaching warning against improper motivation in ascetic practice, not a condemnation of the practices themselves — the surrounding commentary makes clear these practices are praised when undertaken with the right qualities of non-attachment and non-delusion.

- The "thirteen bases of abandonment" refers to the thirteen ascetic practices themselves, understood here as objects of potential attachment that non-attachment must overcome. The text is drawing a subtle distinction: non-attachment counteracts clinging to the practices themselves as possessions or status symbols, while non-delusion counteracts the failure to discern the faults in one's relationship to material supports.

The bile-ailment simile reflects classical Indian medicine: bile disorders were treated with heat, but applying warmth to an already inflamed condition worsens it. The point is that ascetic hardship, which demands endurance, will simply inflame the aversion-dominant temperament rather than subdue it.

The text referenced at the close is the *Vimokṣamārga*, an early Abhidharma-related text on the path, likely a Chinese-transmitted work related to the *Vimuttimagga* tradition, of which this passage appears to be part.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.